From Start *2* Keys

WASHINGTON · 2026 EDITION

The Homebuyer *Guide*

Your step-by-step plan from renting to getting the keys, with Washington down payment help, loan options and the checklists I give my own clients. It's more than just a house. It's your home.

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BEFORE YOU START

It's more than a house. It's your *home*.

For most people, buying a home is the largest investment they'll ever make. But it's not just dollars and cents. It's a place to put down roots, grow your family and make memories. This guide walks you through every step, from your first question to the day you get your keys.

Two questions to ask yourself first

Ideally, your answer to both is a confident "yes."

1. Am I financially ready to own?

Check your credit, review your monthly budget and talk with a trusted lender. That tells you which loan programs you qualify for and what payment feels comfortable. Many buyers qualify for VA, FHA or first-time buyer programs that make owning more doable than they expected.

2. Is now the right time for me?

Timing isn't only about interest rates. It's about your readiness. If you've saved for the upfront costs, lined up financing and connected with an agent you trust, the timing may be right. Waiting for the "perfect" rate can mean paying more for the home later. You can refinance a rate; you can't go back for a price.

Not sure yet? That's what the free homebuyer class and a 1-on-1 buyer plan are for. No pressure, just a clear picture of your options.

START HERE

From start to *keys* in 9 steps

Buying a home is a lot of small, doable steps. Here's the order I walk my clients through, so nothing sneaks up on you.

01 **Get your plan**
Book a free consult. We map your budget, timeline and must-haves.

02 **Take the homebuyer class**
Free and state-certified. It's required for most Washington down payment assistance.

03 **Get pre-approved**
A lender reviews your income, credit and assets and tells you your real number.

04 **Line up down payment help**
See if you qualify for Washington programs (page 7) before you shop.

05 **Shop smart**
Tour homes that fit your numbers and your life. I set up alerts so you see new homes first.

06 **Make a strong offer**
Price, terms and timing that win without overpaying.

07 **Inspection & appraisal**
Protect yourself. Negotiate repairs or credits if needed.

08 **Final loan approval**
Underwriting signs off. Lock your rate, keep your finances steady.

09 **Close & get your keys**
Sign, fund, record. Welcome home.

Typical timeline: 1–3 months to get ready and shop, then about **30–45 days** from accepted offer to keys.

YOUR TEAM

Why a buyer's *agent* matters

Buying a home gets a whole lot easier with the right professional on your side. A good buyer's agent helps you avoid costly mistakes, spots opportunities you'd miss and handles the details so you can focus on finding home.

Before you find the home

- Explain how buyer representation works, including loyalty, confidentiality, full disclosure and accountability
- Walk you through financing and connect you with trusted lenders
- Set up searches and alerts so you see new homes first
- Tour homes with you and give honest, side-by-side comparisons

Once you find it

- Price your offer using recent comparable sales
- Write and explain every term so you approve it
- Negotiate price, repairs and credits on your behalf
- Recommend inspectors and keep the deal on track to closing

Washington buyer agreement: State law requires a written agreement with your buyer's agent, typically signed before you start touring homes. It spells out the services your agent provides and how they're paid. I'll walk you through it line by line, and you can ask anything.

Your homebuying team

Agent
Strategy, showings, offers, negotiation, timeline

Lender
Pre-approval, loan options, rate lock, final approval

Escrow & title
Holds funds, clears title, runs the closing

Inspector
Checks the home's condition top to bottom

Insurance agent
Homeowners policy required before closing

You
Respond quickly, keep finances steady, ask questions

THE MONEY

What it really takes to *buy*

Most buyers need far less than 20% down. Here are the common loan types and their typical minimum down payments.

LOAN TYPE	TYPICAL MINIMUM DOWN	GOOD FIT FOR
FHA	3.5% (with a 580+ credit score)	First-time buyers, lower credit scores, smaller savings
Conventional	3% for many first-time buyers; 5%+ otherwise	Good credit; mortgage insurance can come off later
VA	0%	Eligible veterans, active duty (JBLM!) and some surviving spouses
USDA	0%	Eligible rural and some suburban areas, income limits apply

Plan for these costs too

1–3%
Earnest money
Deposit with your offer. It goes toward your purchase at closing.

2–5%
Closing costs
Lender, title, escrow and prepaid taxes/insurance. Seller credits can help.

$500–$700
Home inspection
Paid upfront. Worth every dollar.

2–3 mo.
Reserves
Savings left after closing for peace of mind.

Think beyond the mortgage

Your monthly payment is more than principal and interest. Budget for **property taxes, homeowners insurance, mortgage insurance (if any), HOA dues, utilities and maintenance**. A good rule of thumb is to set aside 1% of the home's value each year for upkeep.

Ranges are typical estimates, not quotes. Your lender gives exact numbers on your Loan Estimate.

CHOOSING YOUR LOAN

Smart mortgage *choices*

Fixed-rate mortgage

Your rate stays the same for the life of the loan, so your principal and interest never change. Easy to budget and protected if rates rise. Shorter terms (like 15 years) usually have lower rates but higher monthly payments than a 30-year loan.

Adjustable-rate (ARM)

Starts with a lower rate for a set period (often 5, 7 or 10 years), then adjusts up or down based on an index plus a margin, within set caps. Can save money upfront, but your payment could rise later. Best if you plan to sell or refinance before it adjusts.

Lender or mortgage broker?

Direct lender (bank, credit union, mortgage company): makes its own decisions and offers its own loan products.

Mortgage broker: shops your loan with multiple lenders, which can mean more options; may charge a fee.

Either way, compare **Loan Estimates** from 2–3 lenders on the same day. Look at the rate, APR, lender fees and cash to close, not just the rate. For Washington down payment assistance, choose a **WSHFC-approved lender**.

Pre-qualified vs. pre-approved

Pre-qualified is a quick estimate based on what you tell the lender. **Pre-approved** means the lender has verified your income, assets and credit. Sellers take pre-approval much more seriously.

- ✓ Know exactly how much home you can afford
- ✓ Make offers sellers trust
- ✓ Find out if you qualify for programs that stretch your budget

Be honest about your finances. Being upfront with your lender about debts, income changes and savings helps them match you with the right program and avoids surprises in underwriting.

WASHINGTON DOWN PAYMENT HELP

Programs that can cover your *down payment*

These statewide programs from the Washington State Housing Finance Commission (WSHFC) are 0%–low interest second loans with no monthly payment. You repay when you sell, refinance or pay off the home.

PROGRAM	HOW MUCH	KEY POINTS
Home Advantage DPA	Up to 4% of the loan (up to 5% on some conventional loans)	Paired with the Home Advantage mortgage. Income limits apply. No first-time buyer rule.
Opportunity / HomeChoice DPA	Roughly $10,000–$15,000, depending on program	For lower-income buyers; HomeChoice serves buyers with a disability or a household member with a disability.
Covenant Homeownership Program	Up to 20% of the price, capped at $150,000, plus closing costs	First-time buyers who meet income limits and family-history requirements (living in WA before 1968). Funding is limited and the program is under federal review in 2026. Confirm status first.

Your class certificate matters. WSHFC programs require approved homebuyer education. Our free class gives you the Washington certificate.

2026 loan limits (single-family)

Pierce, King & Snohomish counties: $1,063,750 for conforming and FHA loans. **Most other Washington counties:** $832,750 conforming.

Program terms, income limits and funding change often. Always confirm with a WSHFC-approved lender or the free Washington Homeownership Hotline at 1-877-894-4663.

GET PRE-APPROVED

Your document *checklist*

Gather these before you talk to your lender. It makes pre-approval fast and your offer stronger.

Income

- ✓ Last 30 days of pay stubs
- ✓ W-2s for the last 2 years
- ✓ Tax returns for 2 years (if self-employed or commission)
- ✓ Military: latest LES and VA Certificate of Eligibility

Assets

- ✓ Last 2 months of bank statements, all pages
- ✓ Retirement or investment statements
- ✓ Gift letter if family is helping with the down payment

Identity

- ✓ Driver's license or state ID
- ✓ Social Security number
- ✓ Current address and 2-year address history

Credit

- ✓ Check your credit and fix errors early
- ✓ Keep card balances under 30% of limits
- ✓ Know your monthly debts (car, student loans, cards)

Don't do these until after closing

- ✗ Open new credit cards or finance a car or furniture
- ✗ Change jobs or switch to self-employed without talking to your lender
- ✗ Move large sums of money or make big cash deposits you can't document
- ✗ Miss any payments, or co-sign a loan for someone else

THE FUN PART

Finding the home that's right for *you*

Start by separating your **must-haves** from your **nice-to-haves**. Knowing what you can't live without, and where you'll compromise, keeps your search focused and stress-free. Use the Home Search Worksheet on page 12.

Must-haves

Deal-breakers: budget, number of bedrooms, commute, school district, accessibility, room for a home office, parking.

Nice-to-haves

Things you'd love but can add or live without: updated kitchen, second bathroom upstairs, fenced yard, garage shop, view.

Search online, decide in person

Websites and apps are great for photos, virtual tours and neighborhood info. But listings can't show everything: the layout, the noise, the smell, the condition of the roof. Touring in person with your agent is where you catch what photos miss.

At every showing, check

- ✓ Roof, gutters and drainage around the house
- ✓ Signs of water: stains, musty smells, soft floors
- ✓ Windows, heating type and age of the water heater
- ✓ Natural light, noise and street traffic
- ✓ Storage, parking and yard size
- ✓ Visit the neighborhood at night and on a weekend

MAKING THE OFFER

Winning the home, *protected*

When you find the one, I'll write your offer on the standard Washington purchase forms: your price, earnest money, closing and possession dates, and the contingencies that protect you. I'll explain every term so the offer says exactly what you intend.

What happens next

Accepted
You're under contract. On to inspection and financing.

Countered
The seller changes terms. We negotiate back and forth.

Rejected
We regroup, adjust strategy or move to the next home.

A strong offer has

- A fresh pre-approval letter
- A price backed by recent comparable sales
- Clean, clear terms and a realistic closing date
- The right contingencies for you

Common contingencies

- **Inspection:** time to inspect and negotiate repairs
- **Financing:** protects you if the loan falls through
- **Appraisal:** protects you if the home appraises low
- **Title review:** make sure ownership is clean

UNDER CONTRACT

From accepted offer to *keys*

After mutual acceptance

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
Days 1–3	Earnest money to escrow · schedule inspection · lender orders appraisal
Days 3–10	Inspection and repair negotiations · review title and HOA documents
Weeks 2–4	Appraisal · underwriting · get homeowners insurance
3 business days before closing	You receive your Closing Disclosure. Compare it to your Loan Estimate
Closing week	Final walk-through · sign at escrow · loan funds · deed records · keys!

Title search & insurance

Escrow reviews the property's legal history to make sure no one else has a claim to it. Your lender requires a lender's title policy; an owner's policy protects **you** from past errors or missed claims.

Final walk-through

Within a day or two of closing, we tour the home one last time to confirm it's in the condition agreed, repairs are done and everything that stays is still there.

Closing day

You sign your loan and closing documents with escrow and pay your cash to close. Once the loan funds and the deed records with the county, the home is officially yours. Keys usually come the same day or per your possession date.

> **Wire fraud warning:** Scammers send fake wiring instructions by email. Before you send money, **always call your escrow officer at a number you already know** to confirm. I will never email you new wiring instructions.

YOUR WORKSHEET

Home Search *Worksheet*

Fill this out and bring it to your buyer consult. It turns "I'll know it when I see it" into a clear plan.

Price range I'm comfortable with	
Monthly payment target (all-in)	
Cash I have for down payment + closing	
Areas / neighborhoods	
Commute: work, school, base (max minutes)	
Bedrooms / bathrooms	
Home type (house, townhome, condo, multi-unit)	
Move-in timeline	
Loan type I'm leaning toward	

Must-haves

Nice-to-haves

Features to rate

- [ ] Garage
- [ ] Fenced yard
- [ ] Home office
- [ ] Main-floor bedroom
- [ ] Updated kitchen
- [ ] Walk-in closet
- [ ] Basement / storage
- [ ] Room for RV / shop
- [ ] No HOA
- [ ] Single level
- [ ] Near parks / trails
- [ ] Good schools

NEXT STEPS

Ready to go from start to *keys?*

- **Join the free homebuyer class.** Two evenings on Zoom, live Q&A, plus your Washington certificate. fromstart2keys.com/class
- **Book a free 1-on-1 buyer plan.** We'll map your budget, programs and timeline.
- **Get new homes sent to you** the day they hit the market. fromstart2keys.com/search

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